

Features

The vanilla-plain ACI Dimiq 1200 and the boxy HCL W9504 PMP730 are (you guessed it!) the simpletons of the ultra-portable world. The Compaq Presario B1950 is also rather plain-jane, though we must say the build quality of all three models is quite good.

If we could reward outright beauty, we'd have to have cataracts in both eyes not to accolade Sony for the raw sex appeal exuding from the Vaio SZ483N. An absolutely gorgeous-looking hunk of carbon fibre—yes, real carbon fibre—and brushed aluminium alloy encompasses some of the fastest hardware you'll see under a 12.1-inch form factor. This laptop is also ultra-light, courtesy the carbon fibre, and has brilliant ergonomics. Placement of switches and even keypad layout is typically Sony-precise. The only sore point with the ergonomics is the mushy keypad; there is also excessive key travel. The presence of biometrics security via a fingerprint scanner is another utilitarian feature, and we found logging in very convenient—no passwords, just a finger-swipe.

Equally brilliant is the Stamina mode, something the Vaio series proudly sports. There's a switch provided, right next to the Wi-Fi on/off switch that actually switches between Intel onboard graphics and an NVIDIA 7400 Go solution, with a system restart of course.

ASUS' W5Fe is another standout looker with a secondary 2.8-inch LCD screen embedded in the laptop cover. This tiny screen can be used to control a media player. Incidentally, using this screen doesn't eat up system memory: it has 1 GB of Flash memory all to itself. ASUS is to be commended on the brilliant touchpad and keypad feedback.

LG's X-Note C1 looks neat—it's a tablet-PC-type swivel. This is misleading (fooled us!) as it isn't a tablet PC (no touch-screen). The quality of build is good, and though keypad feedback is very good too, the keypad itself isn't too well laid-out. Still, it was heartening to see this sturdy little contestant sport a Core Duo processor with a gigabyte of RAM and a GeForce 7300 Go graphics solution.

Compaq's Presario B1950 had an ace up its sleeve that some of the costlier HP models couldn't match—its touchpad has a matte finish unlike the smooth finishes on the DV6226tx and DV9223tx, and therefore provides more feedback and greater accuracy while scrolling.

Performance

Although performance is definitely not the forte of ultra-portables, prepare to be shocked when you look at the figures the ultra-thin, ultra-light Sony Vaio SZ 483N chalked up. Sporting a top-of-the-line series T7400 Core 2 Duo and a GeForce 7400 Go solution, this notebook is eminently suitable for all your mobile computing needs. The white LED display is crisp



Sony Vaio SZ 483N/C
The ultimate mobile powerhouse



and clear, and working with Windows Vista Ultimate was a pleasure. Add to the equation a massive 160 GB hard drive under that tiny hood, and you'll learn to overlook that Rs 1,24,990 price tag. The Vaio SZ483N also has an excellent wireless solution, and a bandwidth of 2.36 MB/s is enough for even the heaviest browsing and downloading.

A surprise performer was the tiny 10.6-inch-screen-bearing X-Note C1 from LG. With a Core Duo processor that admittedly isn't in the Vaio's league, and a modest GeForce 7300 Go GPU under the hood, this notebook is a great performer too.

The only other laptop that clung to these two leaders was the ASUS W5Fe, whose tenaciousness has to be seen to be believed, considering the lack of dedicated graphics. The ASUS does outscore the X-Note C1 as storage space goes, however.

Among the performance minnows, the Dimiq 1200 fights a valiant albeit doomed-from-the-start battle against the Presario B1950 and the HCL W9504. It's placed last.

The Conclusion

Our hearts prevailed here. The gorgeous Vaio SZ483N/C wins our Best Buy Gold award by a mile and then some! Seriously, take a look at our tables, and you'll see nothing even comes close to the Vaio in this category: a surefire case of done and dusted. This laptop should be the ultimate weapon of choice for the discerning road warrior.

The next-best thing according to us, and our Best Buy Silver winner, is ASUS' funky and functional W5Fe, at a price of just under a lakh.

If you want something reasonably fast in this category but aren't willing to shell out a penny over 50K, the Compaq Presario B1950 is definitely worth taking a long look at. It's got all the features, it's light, ergonomic, and has a great touchpad—all this in a sturdy body that isn't too hard on the eye.

Though definitely not a showstopper, it gets the job done.

As funky as the LG X-Note C1 is, we don't recommend busting 100 grand on something so frivolous when at 25K more, Digit's Golden Boy can be yours!



ASUS W5Fe
Two screens—we love it!

LIFESTYLE NOTEBOOKS

Ever feel proud driving down an expressway in your new Honda City only to be overtaken and dusted by a two-bit kid in a BMW M3? While we don't earn enough to be in either drivers' shoes, we understand (really!) how either one would feel. For people who really wish to wear their attitude, we've got not one but five of these babies, just in case you happened to be on the losing side of our analogy.

Just ASUS and HP make it to this category, where flaunt takes equal ranking with quality—and, of course, performance. Each of these laptops is different in a big way. They are targeted at different audiences.